

Human and Social Challenges in the Field of Economics

— How I came to be
in the Master's Program

FY25 Human and Social Challenges
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Introduction (Notes)

This lecture is based on the speaker's personal experience.

Writing a master's thesis is a self-directed process, The guidance is the responsibility of the regular and secondary supervisors.

The ideas and methodologies that will be presented are,

It is quite possible that it may differ from that of the supervisors.

In such cases, it is recommended to follow the guidance of the regular supervisor.

Self-introduction

Specialty :

Modern Japanese Economic History

Degree :

PhD in Economics 09/2005 (Kanazawa University)

Academic Background (Graduate School) :

03/2001 Completion of graduate studies

Graduate School of Economics, Kanazawa University

1st year 1st semester

How to deal with research topics :

I would like to research *something* about *Manchurian immigrants*.

Details were gradually clarified during the first semester of the first year.

Exercises up to the first semester of the first year:

Random reading of literature on the general framework of the research theme

→ Later, it helped me to *broaden my perspective*.

1st - 1st (supplemental explanation)

How to deal with the research topic (personal statement in detail):

The main points...

To discover **academic issues** in your field of interest at an early stage.

To discover academic issues...

To understand not only the results of each **previous study**, but also **the remaining issues**.

1st - 1st (supplemental explanation)

Relation to the subject matter of this class (personal opinion):

Direction of my master's thesis...

After considering war and immigration as social phenomena, I will elucidate the causal relationship between these phenomena based on their economic backgrounds.

However, I became clearly aware of this after entering the doctoral program.

Social issues reflected by war and immigration...

The existence of "disparity" and "scarcity" inevitably created by a market economy.

Human rights violations in wars are not a priority in economics.

1st - 1st (supplemental explanation)

The Importance of Expanding Your Horizons (Personal Opinion):

A master's thesis is a one-point breakthrough...

It is practically impossible to expand the entire field of study (covering the subject in depth).

→It is impossible to make a full development (covering a certain field in depth).

Points to keep in mind when making a single-point breakthrough...

Understanding of the position of the entire field

Present the possibility of full-field development

→It is necessary to grasp the "big picture" of the full-field (expand the field of vision).

It is difficult to make the research theme alone have social and academic significance.

1st year summer break

Sudden death of the primary supervisor:

I felt lost and disempowered, and could no longer do my research.

←My primary supervisor who guided me to enter graduate school and get married.

The current Kobayashi Laboratory (Economics) was first "headed" by that faculty member.

1st year 2nd semester

Change of supervisory structure and resumption of research:

Change of primary supervisor...

Under his guidance, I began to **narrow down** my research theme in earnest.

→The Manchurian Emigration of the Hokushin (northern Nagano Prefecture) region

= Narrowing down target areas

→**Field research during spring break**

Utilizing the network of the new primary supervisor

1st – 2nd (supplemental explanation)

Direction of narrowing down the target cases:

- ◆ Target cases
- ◆ Target period
- ◆ Target area
- ◆ Analysis method, etc.

Rationality of "Northern Nagano":

- ◆ There is not much research accumulation (however, Nagano itself is the largest sending prefecture)
 - = Academic significance
- ◆ Land survey is available.

It is quite difficult to study an area without a land survey.
However, land survey is irrelevant to academic significance.

1st year spring break

Field Survey and Theme Change:

Professor A's laboratory at Shinshu University...

Visited Professor A's laboratory just before his retirement to discuss desired research theme.

→He informed me that there are almost no **primary sources** in the Hokushin area.

Nagano City History Compilation Office...

With the help of Professor A's handlers, I spent about 10 days browsing through the materials I had collected.

→Reached a decision to change the research theme and further narrow down the research focus.

2nd year 1st semester

Changed themes:

"Shinano Kyoiku-kai Association", "Youth Volunteer Corps",
"All Nagano Prefecture with a focus on the southern part".

Reorganization of previous research:

I reorganized the previous studies based on the new theme.

If the perspective changes, the viewpoint (evaluation) of
previous research will also change.

Chapter organization:

Concretize the structure of the paper

2nd year Summer break

Field survey again:

Surveyed at...

Nagano: Libraries (Iida City, Suwa City), Shimoina Board of Education, private homes

Tokyo: National Diet Library, Ohara Research Institute (Hosei University)

The main objective was to collect primary source materials (materials available only there).

At private homes, interviews were conducted.

At that time, Kanazawa University did not have an ethics review system.

2nd Summer break (supplemental explanation)

Aspects of the interview survey:

Mr. N (introduced by Professor A)...

Questions and subjective experiences about Mr. N's articles, etc.

= Hybrid of semi-structured and unstructured interviews

Mr. Y (introduced by Mr. N)...

Subjective experience

This interview was decided on short notice, but he talked for a whole day.

Semi-structured interviews are efficient but not a panacea.

2nd year 2nd semester

Writing:

All I did was write. (Along with raising my son, of course.)

The fact that I did not need to do any additional research because of the extensive research I had done up to that point (especially during the summer break in the second year) was very significant.

Publication of new previous research:

In December, a book was published that largely overlapped with the theme of my master's thesis.

→ I was able to overcome this by partially revising my master's thesis while incorporating its results.

2nd – 2nd (completion of the manuscript)

Pitfalls of early completion:

I completed my thesis half a month before the deadline to coincide with an entrance exam for a doctoral program at another university.

→I was forced to help a classmate with his master's thesis....

Recommendation for early completion of thesis:

Spend a week or so forgetting about the thesis.

→The narrowing of vision caused by concentrating on the thesis is almost eliminated.

→Minor revisions in that state increase the degree of completion of the thesis.

Conclusion (on the subject of this lesson)

Findings and significance through the Master's thesis:

I became more aware of the fact that non-economic factors are involved in the economic phenomenon of immigration.

I have acquired doubts that became the starting point for my own views on the "problems of capitalism" and "problems of market economy" that have been attracting attention again in recent years.

Conclusion (on the subject of this lesson)

A market economy that is becoming noticeably dysfunctional,

and capitalism, which is the most compatible with the market economy, is amplifying the dysfunction,

The current economic system is based on these two foundations.

The pursuit of improvement of this system is the task of society in the field of economics (and the social demand for economics is to show the way to that end).